STRATEGY AND IMPLEMENTATION

The Estimator Keeps Asking for the Latest Drawing

Before you pay to make a task faster, find out why your team has to do it again.



Fran Herrera · Co-founder, Strategy & Operations
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Your estimator has spent half a day pricing a restaurant build-out. She gets to the service counter and notices the electrical plan shows it on one side of the room. The millwork drawing shows it on the other. Sales forwarded both files. The architect issued a revision on Friday, and the project folder still gives her both answers.

You've seen the same thing happen on four other bids. At the operations meeting, someone suggests a tool that reads drawing sets and emails whoever sent them when a sheet is missing. The estimator has all the sheets. What she needs is someone to tell her which set to price.

Before automating, follow a real job to the event that creates the recurring task. Check whether the business lacks information, an agreed rule, authority to act, or a reliable way to carry out an established step. Choose an intervention you can test against the result the customer and the business need.

What are you trying to make easier?

Define the work in terms of what the next person needs. "Chase drawings" is a task. "Give estimating a set it can rely on, with exceptions it can see" describes the outcome. That change in wording gives you more than one way to solve it.

Toyota describes a production practice called *jidoka*. Equipment can stop when it detects an abnormality. A worker who sees a problem can signal for help or stop the line. The stop keeps a defect from moving to the next stage and makes the problem visible to someone who can deal with it. Toyota describes this as part of how it builds quality into the work. Toyota Production System · Toyota plant tour on jidoka

The same question comes up behind a coffee counter. Starbucks reported that in store trials, baristas changed the order in which they prepared espresso and steamed milk. The company says the change saved time while preserving taste and quality. The thing to borrow is the test. Watch someone do the work, try a different sequence, and compare what reaches the customer. Your first intervention may be a change to the order of two steps. Starbucks' account of its in-store trials

In estimating, the equivalent of a visible stop might be "release held pending confirmation of sheet E-204." The estimator can continue pricing work unaffected by that sheet. One named person gets the question. The hold stays attached to the bid so sales can see what has yet to be priced. The

intervention is useful because it says where progress is possible and where guessing would create work for the next team.

How do you tell which fix the work calls for?

Compare what the team knew when it acted with what was needed for a sound decision. Open the actual files and messages. Ask which revision was issued, when estimating saw it, and who could confirm its use. Each answer points to a different first test.

What you find on the job	The change worth testing
The architect sent an addendum and it stayed in one inbox.	Give incoming addenda a shared destination and assign someone to reconcile them with the active set.
Everyone saw both versions and assumed somebody else had checked them.	Assign authority to release a set and make release status visible.
The architect has yet to resolve the conflict.	Ask a specific scope question and show the pending assumption or exclusion in the bid.
The set is confirmed, but the estimator keeps copying file details by hand.	Test extracting the details from the confirmed set, with a check against the source and a way to flag uncertain results.

If two bids had missing addenda and two had disagreements nobody could resolve, one workflow may help both cases get routed. The company still needs two different answers. Start with the cases that actually recur and cost the team something. A process that handles the common case and flags a meaningful exception is easier to evaluate than a system asked to interpret everything.

When can you fix the problem before the task exists?

Look for a handoff where someone already has the information or authority that the team has to chase later. Put it into the work at that point and check whether the repeat task disappears. In the restaurant example, the person assembling the bid package can attach the confirmed scope before assigning it to estimating. If the package arrives as a forwarded thread, an automatic reminder still leaves an estimator piecing together the record.

Consider a contractor that gets asked every week to book a return visit for a warranty concern. The team wants to automate appointment scheduling. Review a few visits first. If three concerned an expected sound at startup that customers were never told about, a clear handover and an explanation of what to report could help. If the calls came from equipment that actually failed, route the case to the team that can investigate and look for the upstream defect. If customers knew what they were seeing and had trouble reaching you, improve access. Three teams would own those changes. All three problems could have appeared on the same list of calls.

What should you prove before rolling a change out?

Choose a small group of bids and define what a valid release looks like. Record where versions disagree, who settles the question, how long that takes, and whether the issued estimate still needs correction. Check for new work the change creates for sales or project teams.

Here's a practical **Intervention Decision Record** entry for the restaurant bid. *Observation* — electrical and millwork disagree. *Evidence* — issued sheets and Friday's addendum. *Open question* — does the later drawing govern the counter or only the equipment? *Decision owner* — preconstruction lead obtains confirmation. *First test* — one confirmed set and a visible hold on the affected scope. *Stop condition* — an unresolved conflict appears in an issued quote as though it were settled.

Run the test manually first if that is enough to establish the rule. If the new release step takes sales an extra hour per bid, track that effort alongside time saved in estimating. Then decide whether to simplify the procedure or automate the repetitive part. Record revisions caught before issue separately from turnaround. A faster bid with a wrong scope creates a very different commercial result.

Test a clean set and a messy one. On a clean set, the estimator should be able to tell which documents to use without more messages. On a messy set, the process should show the conflict and preserve the ability to price unaffected work. If you automate extraction, open the source beside the result and make the release owner check a representative sample. Watch for an apparently clean output that hides an unresolved decision. That's the failure a well-designed stop is there to catch.

Three checks before committing a budget.

- Follow the recurring task back to the event that creates it.
- Give somebody authority over the exception and make the decision visible to the next team.
- Check whether the change improves what leaves the process, along with how long it takes.

The next time two drawings put the same counter in different places, your estimator should be able to show the conflict, see who's handling it, and finish the work she can stand behind.

Frequently asked questions

What kinds of tasks are good candidates for automation?

Start with frequent steps that use reliable inputs and have a verifiable result, such as copying fields from an approved record or sending a reminder after a defined event. Specify what the system should do with missing or contradictory information.

What if the team disagrees about the cause?

Bring two or three recent examples and compare the records in time order. Pick a change that would produce different results depending on which explanation is true. Keep the conclusion open until you see what the test yields.

Can we estimate savings before the pilot?

Estimate current handling time from a sample and write down which part the change could remove. Include review and exception handling. Treat the result as a planning estimate until the pilot shows how much time the team actually gets back.

Toyota and Starbucks are public examples. The estimating scenario and test are illustrative.